



India's Must-Do List

- Strengthen and support the Hasina Government as her stability is pivotal for India.
- Continue to work with Dhaka to seek handover of fugitives and ensure a crackdown on **terror camps in a time-bound manner.**
- Expedite border fencing and install sensors along the border to curb illegal smuggling and immigration.
- Work the back channels to settle outstanding issues like water-sharing disputes and border management issues.
- Work on confidence-building measures, including people-to-people contacts, to instill trust and counter anti-India elements.

Bangladesh has assured us that their territory will not be allowed for anti-India activities. We will also share intelligence information with each other," Krishna told INDIA TODAY.

While India's dossier handed over to Dhaka contained information that Barua and Chetia had Bangladeshi passports in the name of Kamruz Zaman Khan and Abdul Aziz respectively and have been travelling freely, Dhaka is yet to give any firm assurances on their handover. The other thorny issue is that of the sharing of river waters. The current hot potato is over the Tipaimukh dam to be built on the river Barak in Manipur, which has led to a political storm in Dhaka. India has now told Bangladesh that it will share hydrological data with them to allay fears about the diversion of waters. Moni said, "We are committed to eliminating terrorism in all its forms and have agreed to resolve all outstanding issues."

For India, investing in its relationship with Dhaka also stems from a realisation that Bangladesh is important for land-route connectivity for its seven north-east states. But this is also mired in political controversy as the Bangladesh Nationalist Party-led (BNP) Opposition is accusing the Government of a sell-out. There was a proposal for a gas pipeline from Myanmar passing through Bangladesh, which was opposed by the previous government in Dhaka. The hope is that it could be revived during Hasina's tenure as this would provide economic dividends to both the countries. Besides, Pakistan—which has never been able to accept the reality of Bangladesh since 1971—has been fishing in troubled waters. The opposition BNP and Jamaat that are remote-controlled from Pakistan have been fomenting trouble for the present Government, dubbing it pro-India. In the face of such opposition,

Hasina has had little room to manoeuvre until she is seen to be getting something big in return.

But given the Congress's traditional ties with the Awami League and the fact that Hasina has been the top target for extremists ever since she started cracking down on them, Delhi is now engaging Dhaka to strengthen the hands of Bangladesh's prime minister. Prudently, India has to do what it is trying to in Nepal—embark on a brick-by-brick approach for repairing ties by playing generous neighbour and giving concessions in exchange for time-bound progress on its security concerns.

Next month, when Prime Minister Manmohan Singh hosts Hasina in Delhi, the message from India should be that while the country is prepared to go more than a mile on key bilateral issues, it does expect that Dhaka will reciprocate. But for now the signs do look encouraging. ■